

THEME-7

AN IMPERIAL CAPITAL: VIJAYANAGARA

1. Name different dynasties which would rule over Vijayanagara.

- Sangama Dynasty
- Saluva Dynasty
- Tuluva Dynasty (Krishnadeva raya)
- Aravidu Dynasty

2. When and by whom was the Vijayanagara Empire was found? Also explain its expansion.

- The Empire was founded by two brothers Harihara and Bukka in 1336.
- The empire contained people who spoke different languages and followed different religions.
- It stretched from river Krishna in the north to the extreme south of the peninsula.

3. Who was Colin Mackenzie? What was his contribution towards Indian History?

Colin Mackenzie born in 1754 was famous engineer, surveyor and cartographer. In 1815 he was appointed the first Surveyor General of India, a post he held till his death in 1821.

His contribution towards Indian History

- He prepared the first survey map of the Vijayanagara.
- He embarked on collecting local histories and surveying historic sites in order to better understand India's past and make governance of the colony easier.

4. Who was the most famous ruler of Vijayanagara? To which dynasty did he belong?

Or

Which dynasty did Krishnadeva Raya belong to? Mention his achievements and expansion and consolidation.

- The most famous ruler of Vijayanagara was Krishnadeva Raya.
- He belongs to Tuluva Dynasty.

Achievements

- Krishnadeva Raya is credited with building some fine temples and adding impressive gopurams to many important south Indian temples.
- He also founded a suburban township near Vijayanagara called Nagalapuram after his mother.
- He laid the foundation of vast empire by defeating the rulers of Orissa along with the sultan of Bijapur and Golconda.

Expansion and consolidation

One of his expansion and consolidation policies include capturing of Richur Doab lying between Tungabhadra and Krishna river.

5. Throw light on the different aspects of the prosperous trade of the Vijayanagara?

- Warfare during these times depended upon effective cavalry, the import of horses from Arabia and Central Asia was very important for rival kingdoms.
- This trade was initially controlled by Arab traders. Local communities of merchants known as kudirai chettis or horse merchants also participated in these exchanges.

- The Portuguese, who arrived on the west coast of the subcontinent and attempted to establish trading and military stations. Their superior military technology, especially the use of muskets.
- Vijayanagara was also noted for its markets dealing in spices, textiles and precious stones.
- Trade was often regarded as a status symbol for such cities, which boasted of a wealthy population that demanded high-value exotic goods, especially precious stones and jewellery.
- The revenue derived from trade in turn contributed significantly to the prosperity of the state.

6. Who were Amara Nayakas? Examine the role of Amara Nayakas in Vijayanagara Empire?

Amara Nayakas were those who exercised power in the empire. They were military chiefs who usually controlled forts and had armed supporters. They usually spoke telegu or kannada.

ROLE OF AMARA NAYAKAS

- The amara-nayakas were military commanders who were given territories to govern by the raya.
- They collected taxes and other dues from peasants, craftspersons and traders in the area.
- They retained part of the revenue for personal use and for maintaining a stipulated contingent of horses and elephants.
- Some of the revenue was also used for the maintenance of temples and irrigation works.
- The amara-nayakas sent tribute to the king annually and personally appeared in the royal court with gifts to express their loyalty.
- During the seventeenth century, many of these nayakas established independent kingdoms. This hastened the collapse of the central imperial structure.

7. What do you know about Mahanavami Dibba? Mention the rituals associated with Mahanavami Dibba?

The “Mahanavami Dibba” is a massive platform rising from a base of about 11,000 sq. ft to a height of 40 ft. There is evidence that it supported a wooden structure. The base of the platform is covered with relief carvings.

RITUALS

- Rituals associated with the structure probably coincided with Mahanavami (literally, the great ninth day) of the ten-day Hindu festival during the autumn months of September and October, known variously as Dusehra , Durga Puja and Navaratri or Mahanavami.
- The Vijayanagara kings displayed their prestige, power and suzerainty on this occasion.
- The ceremonies performed on the occasion included worship of the image, worship of the state horse, and the sacrifice of buffaloes and other animals.
- Dances, wrestling matches, and processions of caparisoned horses, elephants and chariots and soldiers.
- On this occasion the nayakas brought rich gifts for the king as well as the stipulated tribute.

8. Discuss whether the term “Royal Centre is appropriate describe for the port of city for which it is used.

Or

Why was the South-western part of Vijayanagara settlement designated as Royal Centre?

Or

Mention the features of Hazara Rama Temple.

- The term Royal Centre is an appropriate description for the part of the city for which it is used. Although, it designated as Royal Centre, it included over 60 temples.
 - This indicates that rulers who tried to establish and legitimate their power and authority through association with the divinities housed in the shrines.
 - One of the most beautiful buildings in the Royal Centre was Lotus Mahal, so named by British traveler in 19th century.
 - Historians are not quite sure what the building was used for. But according to Mackenzie, it may have been a council chamber, a place where the king met his advisors.
 - While, temples were in the sacred centre, there were several evidences found in Royal Centre also.
 - One of the most spectacular of these is one as Hazara Rama Temple.
 - This was probably meant to be used by the king and his family.
 - It included the scenes of Ramayana sculpted on the inner walls of the shrine. Though, images in central shrine are missing.
9. Many structures at Vijayanagara were destroyed when the city was sacked.

10. Explain how the Fortification and roads in the city of Vijayanagara were unique and impressive.

Or

Explain the striking features about the fortification of the Vijayanagara.

Or

“Abdur Razzaq, an ambassador of Persia, was impressed by the fortification of Vijayanagara empire.” Justify the statement.

FORTIFICATION

According to the writings of the various foreign travellers, like Abdur Razzaq, it had been clear that in Vijayanagara Empire there was a planned system of Fortification.

- There were seven lines of forts. This encircled city, agricultural hinterland and forests.
- The outmost wall linked the hills surrounding the city. This wall was built with wedge shaped blocks of stone. Inner portion of wall was of earth packed with rubble.
- This fortification enclosed agricultural tracts like cultivated fields, gardens and forests. The evidences of agricultural tracts have found between sacred centre and urban core by the modern archaeologists.
- To irrigate these tracts, there was an elaborate canal system which drew water from the Tungabhadra River.
- In the Medieval Period, sieges laid to starve the defenders into submission.
- These sieges could last even for months and years. So,
- the rulers built large granaries within fortified areas. So Vijayanagara rulers adopted an elaborate strategy to protect their agricultural belts.

- Second line of fortification surrounded the inner core of the urban complex.
- Third line of fortification went around the royal centre. There were well guarded gates to enter the fort.
- These gates led to the major roads.

ROADS

- The roads linked different parts of the city of Vijayanagara.
- They also led out of the city. Roads have been identified by tracing paths through gateways and by finds of pavements.
- They went through the whole valley, avoided rocky terrain.
- Some of the most important roads extended from temple gateways and were lined by bazaars.

11. What does the architecture of buildings like the Lotus Mahal and Elephant stables tell us about the rulers who commissioned them?

- The architecture of these buildings showed the combination of architectural features of Indo-Islamic technique.
- Kings were Hindu by faith but they adopted liberal view. The mixture of culture is a unique feature of India's Heritage.
- Historians are not quite sure what the building was used for.
- But according to Mackenzie, it may have been a council chamber, a place where the king met his advisors.
- Elephant stable was located near the Lotus Mahal indicated that the empire has vast army and troops.
- The Vijayanagara rulers had to fight many battles and wars with their enemies.
- There were thick forests and during the peace days elephants might have been used to draw heavy logs from the forests.

12. Describe the two main platforms found in Vijayanagara's king's palace.

- The two main platforms were "**Audience hall**" and the "**Mahanavami Dibba**".
- The Audience hall is a high platform with slots for wooden pillars. The pillars support a staircase going to the second floor.
- The pillars have been found at close intervals. Thus, there was very little free space between the pillars and it is not clear for what purpose the hall was used for.
- The Mahanavami Dibba was located on one of the highest points in the city. It is a massive platform rising from a base of about 11,000 sq.ft to a height of 40 ft.
- Evidence shows that it supported a wooden structure.
- The base of the platform is covered with fine carvings. Many rituals associated with the Mahanavami festivals carried on here.

13. How was the water requirement of Vijayanagara met?

Or

Explain how the people of Vijayanagara obtained water for their needs.

- Reservoirs, canals and tanks were the means by which the water requirements of Vijayanagara were met.
- Vijayanagara is situated in the natural basin formed by the river Tungabhadra.
- Many streams flowed down the river from the granite hills which surrounded the city. A no. of embankments has been built along the streams to create reservoirs.
- The most important tank was the Kamlapuram tank which helped to irrigate the nearby fields. A channel from this tank also took water to the “Royal centre”.
- The most important canal was the Hiriya canal. This canal’s source of water was a dam built across the Tungabhadra.
- It helped to irrigate valley that separated the “sacred centre” from the “urban core”. This canal was built by Sangama dynasty.

14. Analyze the various source materials which have helped to reconstruct the history of Vijayanagara.

- Oral traditions, monuments, inscriptions and the accounts of foreign travelers have helped to reconstruct the history of Vijayanagara.
- Colin Mackenzie was able to prepare the first survey map of Hampi because he got his initial information from priests of the Virupaksha temple and Pampa devi shrine.
- A large no. of inscriptions of the Vijayanagara king and their nayakas recording donations of various temples as well as describing important events have been found.
- The remains of the Vijayanagara city, other archaeological finds, temples and other monuments have given us an idea of the cultural influences at work.
- The buildings that have survived give us an idea of the materials and techniques used
- A study of the fortifications of Vijayanagara city has enabled us to analyze the defense requirements and military preparedness of the city.
- Historians attempting to reconstruct the history of the Vijayanagara have used information from the above sources and collated it with accounts of foreign travelers and the other literary works.
- The account of Foreign travelers like the Italian trader Nicolo de Conti, the Persian ambassador Abdur Razzaq and the Russian merchant Afanasii Nikitin among others have added to our knowledge about this period.

15. Trace the rise and decline of Vijayanagara.

Or

“Strain began to show within the imperial structure following Krishnadeva Raya ‘s death in 1529.” Critically examine the statement.

- Vijayanagara was founded by the Sangama dynasty which remained in power till 1485. They were deposited by Saluvas who ruled till 1503.
- The next dynasty to rule was to rule was Tuluva dynasty whose most famous king was Krishnadeva Raya. During his reign, the empire reached the peak of its prosperity.

- After the Krishnadeva Raya's death, the empire began to collapse. Rebellious military chiefs harassed his successors.
- By 1542, power slipped into the hands of Aravidu dynasty which ruled till the 17th century.
- In 1565, the battle of Talikota took place. Rama Raya the chief minister alienated the rulers of Bijapur, Ahmadnagar and Golconda.
- These three rulers formed an alliance, decisively defeated the Vijayanagara army and sacked the city.
- The power centre of the empire now shifted eastwards under the Aravidu dynasty.

16. For what purpose were the halls of the Virupaksha temple used? What were the features of the chariot streets that existed in the temple complexes?

OR

How were the halls of Virupaksha temple used? Mention any two purposes.

- The Virupaksha temple was built in the 9th-10th centuries.
- It had a hall in front of the main shrine.
- This hall was made by Krishnadeva Raya to mark his accession to the throne.
- Such halls were used for variety of purposes. In some of these halls the images of the gods were placed.
- In a few other halls, special programmes of music, dance and dramas were held.
- Few other halls were used to celebrate the marriages of deities. In some other halls, the swings of the deities were installed.
- The chariot streets extended from the temple Gopuram in a straight line.
- They were paved with slabs of stone.
- They had lines of pillared pavilions where the merchants set up their shops.

17. State the main features of the Virupaksha and Vitthala temples.

- The Virupaksha temple was built over a long period of time. The earliest shrine was built in 9th-10th century. It was substantially enlarged by the kings of the Vijayanagara Empire.
- Krishnadeva Raya built the hall in front of the main shrine which is decorated with carved pillars to mark his accession to the throne.
- He also constructed the Eastern Gopuram.
- Halls were used for variety of purposes. In some of these halls the images of the gods were placed. In a few other halls, special programmes of music, dance and dramas were held.
- Few other halls were used to celebrate the marriages of deities. In some other halls, the swings of the deities were installed.

- In the Vitthala temple, the principal deity was Vitthala, a form of Vishnu generally worshipped in Maharashtra.
- The introduction of the worship of the deity in Karnataka is another indication of the ways in which the rulers of Vijayanagara drew on different traditions to create an imperial culture.
- This temple too has several halls and a unique shrine designed as a chariot.
- A characteristic feature of the temple complexes is the chariot streets that extended from the temple gopuram in a straight line.
- These streets were paved with stone slabs and lined with pillared pavilions in which merchants set up their shops.

18. What impression of the lives of the ordinary people of Vijayanagara can you cull from the various descriptions in the chapter?

- Archaeologists found fine Chinese porcelain in some areas, including in the north-eastern corner of the urban core and suggest that these areas may have been occupied by rich traders.
- Muslim residential quarter also existed in these areas as can be seen by the tombs and mosques found here.
- Though, the remains of the houses of ordinary people have not survived, they have been described in the accounts of the Portuguese traveler Barbosa.
- The other houses of the people are thatched, and well-built and arranged according to occupations, in long streets with many open places.
- Field surveys indicate that the entire area was dotted with numerous shrines and small temples, pointing to the prevalence of a variety of cults, perhaps supported by different communities.
- The surveys also indicate that wells, rainwater tanks as well as temple tanks may have served as sources of water to the ordinary town dwellers.